

Inherited Corruption

doc-inherited-corruption

Hamartiology · Original Sin · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness direct
variants not in scope

Statement under examination

All human beings are born with a sinful nature inherited from Adam, sharing in his corruption, and are by nature objects of divine wrath.

In plain language

Across the Hebrew and Greek texts, several writers describe humans as sinful from the very start, not only after later choices. In Psalm 51 the writer says he was brought forth in iniquity ('I was brought forth', cholalti) and that in sin ('sin', chet) his mother conceived him, and the verb for brought forth is a passive form, so he is the one being birthed into that condition. Job 14:4 asks who can bring a clean thing ('clean', tahor) out of an unclean ('unclean', tame) and answers no one. Genesis 8:21 says the inclination ('inclination', yetser) of the human heart is evil ('evil', ra) from youth, and Psalm 58:3 says the wicked go astray from the womb. In the New Testament Paul says in Romans 5 that through one man sin ('sin', hamartia) entered the world and death ('death', thanatos) spread to all, and that death reigned even over people who had not broken a direct command the way Adam did, which only makes sense if some liability is carried rather than only earned. He also says that through one man's disobedience the many were constituted sinners, using a verb ('to constitute, appoint', kathistemi) that elsewhere means to appoint or place into a position, not merely to behave badly. Ephesians 2 adds that we were by nature ('by nature', phusei) children of wrath ('wrath', orge), like everyone else. So the claim that people start out in a sinful condition, before their own acts, rests on dense, repeated words spanning the Psalms, Job, Genesis, and Paul. Where the text leaves room, and why thoughtful readers still differ, is the exact mechanism. The key Greek phrase in Romans 5:12, often rendered because all sinned ('in/because of which all sinned', eph ho pantes hemarton), can also be read in whom all sinned or with the result that all sinned, and the grammar itself does not settle which. The word translated by nature (phusis) in Ephesians is also used elsewhere for ordinary natural instinct and for kind or species, so it shows a native condition but does not by itself prove a corruption passed down specifically from Adam as opposed to inherited guilt or an inherited bent. The from-birth sinfulness is firm. The precise way it descends is the part the words leave open.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H2114	זָר	zur	be a stranger	
H2342	חָוָל	chul	to twist	60
H2399	חַטָּא	chet	sin	33
H2889	טָהוֹר	tahor	pure	96
H2931	טָמֵא	tame	unclean	88
H3336	יֵצֶר	yetser	intention	9
H5771	עוֹן	awon	iniquity	233

G0076	Αδάμ	Adam	Adam	9
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	174
G0268	ἁμαρτωλός	hamartōlos	sinful	
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthropos	a human	567
G0936	βασιλεύω	basileuō	to reign	
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	367
G2288	θάνατος	thanatos	death	121
G2525	καθίστημι	kathistemi	to appoint/conduct	22
G2631	κατάκριμα	katakrima	condemnation	3
G3498	νεκρός	nekros	dead	132
G3709	ὀργή	orge	wrath	36
G3876	παρακοή	parakoē	disobedience	
G3900	παράπτωμα	paraptoma	trespass	21
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	
G4561	σὰρξ	sarx	flesh	151
G5043	τέκνον	teknon	child	
G5218	ὑπακοή	hupakoē	obedience	
G5449	φύσις	phusis	nature	14

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Two claims must be separated. That humanity is sinful from birth, before any moral act, is densely and spread across the whole Bible (pan-canonically) attested. Psalm 51:7 Hebrew (English 51:5) reads 'in iniquity I was brought forth' (be-awon cholalti), with 'I was brought forth' (cholalti) a Polal (passive intensive) perfect (a completed action whose result still stands), meaning I was brought forth in iniquity, and 'and in sin she conceived me' (u-be-chet yechemathni immi), in sin my mother conceived me. Job 14:4 denies by rhetorical question that a clean thing (tahor) can come from an unclean thing (tame). Genesis 8:21 grounds the inclination, 'the inclination of the heart of man is evil from his youth' (yetser lev ha-adam ra mi-ne'urav), evil from youth. Ephesians 2:3 calls the prior state 'by nature children of wrath' (phusei tekna orges). Romans 5:14 has death reigning even over those who did not sin in the likeness of Adam, and 5:19 says 'were constituted' or 'were appointed' (kathistemi, aorist passive (a completed past action, with the subject receiving the action), constituted, appointed) the many sinners through one disobedience. That much is decisive. But the precise mechanism the stem encodes, an inherited corruption descending and shared from Adam as distinct from imputed guilt or merely transmitted inclination, is lexically underdetermined, because the crux clause 'in/because of which all sinned' (eph ho pantes hemarton) in Romans 5:12 admits multiple grammatical construals and 'nature' (phusis) carries several attested senses.

Scripture

Ps.51.5 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H5771 עוֹן, H2342 חוֹל, H2399 חַטָּא.

Force. The Hebrew (verse 7 in the Hebrew numbering) reads 'in iniquity I was brought forth and in sin she conceived me, my mother' (be-awon cholalti u-be-chet yechemathni immi). The verb 'I was brought forth' (cholalti) is the root 'to bring forth, to writhe in labour' (chul) in the Polal stem (a passive intensive form), a passive intensive perfect (a completed action whose result still stands) first singular, I was brought forth, so the speaker is the object of the birthing, not the agent. The paired clause has his mother as subject, 'she conceived me' (yechemathni), she conceived me, in 'sin' (chet). The two prepositional phrases with the 'bet' (the Hebrew preposition meaning 'in') of circumstance locate iniquity and sin at the moment of gestation and birth, before any personal act. Hebrew poetic intensification pairs the two lines. What the words do NOT specify is whether the iniquity is the speaker's own inherited condition or a description of the sinful environment of conception. The dominant reading takes it as the speaker's native condition.

Job.14.4 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H2931 טָמֵא, H2889 טָהוֹר.

Force. 'Who can give a clean thing out of an unclean? No one' (mi yitten tahor mi-tame lo echad). A rhetorical question, who can give a clean thing out of an unclean, answered no one ('no one', lo echad). The interrogative 'who' (mi) plus the negation frames a categorical impossibility, applied in context to one born of woman (compare Job 15:14, Job 25:4). The terms 'clean' (tahor) and 'unclean' (tame) are the cultic clean and unclean vocabulary, here extended to human descent. The verse asserts that uncleanness propagates through generation but does not by itself define the uncleanness as guilt versus moral corruption.

Gen.8.21 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H3336 יָצָר.

Force. 'For the inclination of the heart of man is evil from his youth' (ki yetser lev ha-adam ra mi-ne'urav). The noun 'inclination, frame, formed thing' (yetser) (inclination, frame, formed thing) construct with 'heart' (lev) (heart) is said to be 'evil' (ra) (evil) from youth. 'Inclination' (yetser) is rare (nine occurrences) but here clearly names a settled disposition of the human heart from early life, paralleled in Genesis 6:5 where every 'inclination' (yetser) of the thoughts of the heart is only 'evil' (ra) all the day. This grounds the from-origin inclination, though 'inclination' (yetser) denotes disposition rather than imputed legal liability.

Rom.5.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1520 εἶς, G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G0266 ἁμαρτία, G2288 θάνατος

Force. 'Through one man sin entered into the world, and through sin death, and so to all men death passed, in/because of which all sinned' (di' henos anthropou he hamartia eis ton kosmon eiselthen, kai dia tes hamartias ho thanatos, kai houtos eis pantas anthropous ho thanatos dielthen, eph ho pantes hemarton). The agency phrase 'through' (dia) plus genitive (a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form) locates sin's entry through one man, and the consecutive 'so, thus' (houtos) with the universalizing 'to all' (eis pantas) establishes propagation of death to all. The crux is the closing 'in/because of which all sinned' (eph ho pantes hemarton). The relative pronoun phrase 'in/because of which' (eph ho) is read at least three ways, causal (because all sinned), relative or consecutive (with the result that all sinned), or, taking 'which' (ho) as masculine referring back to the one man, in whom all sinned. The aorist 'all sinned' (hemarton, a completed past action) is a completed past act. The Greek itself does not rank these construals, which is why the mechanism of transmission is contested at the text level even though the entry through one man is plain.

Rom.5.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2288 θάνατος, G0936 βασιλεύω, G0076 Ἀδάμ

Force. 'Death reigned from Adam until Moses even over those who did not sin in the likeness of the transgression of Adam' (ebasileusen ho thanatos apo Adam mechri Mouseos kai epi tous me hamartasantas epi to homoiomati tes parabaseos Adam). Death reigned from Adam to Moses even over those who did not sin in the likeness of Adam's transgression. The participle phrase 'those not having sinned' (tous me hamartasantas) in that specific manner is the strongest single clause against a pure personal-imitation reading, because it shows death (the wage of sin) extending to those who had no Adamic-style command to break. This implies a liability not grounded in their own equivalent act. It still does not, by lexis alone, decide between inherited guilt and inherited corruption as the ground.

Rom.5.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3900 παράπτωμα, G2631 κατάκριμα, G3956 πᾶς

Force. 'Through one trespass to all men to condemnation' (di' henos paraptomatos eis pantas anthropous eis katakrima). The forensic noun 'condemnation' (katakrima) (condemnation, only three NT occurrences, all in Romans at 5:16, 5:18, 8:1) plus the universalizer 'all men' (pantas anthropous) entail that the one trespass yields a condemnation reaching all. The parallel structure (as through one, so to all) carries the corporate movement. The verse is the clearest single statement that the verdict reaches all through one.

Rom.5.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2525 καθίστημι, G3876 παρακοή, G0268 ἁμαρτωλός

Force. 'Through the disobedience of the one man, the many were constituted sinners' (dia tes parakoes tou henos anthropou hamartoloi katestathesan hoi polloi). The verb 'to constitute, appoint, set in place' (kathistemi), here aorist passive (a completed past action, with the subject receiving the action) 'they were constituted' (katestathesan) (were constituted, were appointed), is across its 22 canon occurrences a verb of placing into an office or state (set over a household in Matthew 24:45 and 25:21 and 23, appointed in Acts 6:3 and 7:10 and 7:27 and 7:35 and Titus 1:5 and Hebrews 5:1 and 7:28, rendered or made in James 3:6 and 4:4 and 2 Peter 1:8). It is not an iterative verb of repeated behaviour. So the many were placed into the category sinner through the disobedience of the one, which resists a reduction to mere imitation. The verb names the result, not the mechanism.

Eph.2.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5449 φύσις, G3709 ὀργή, G5043 τέκνον

Force. 'We were children by nature of wrath, as also the rest' (emetha tekna phusei orges hos kai hoi loipoi). The dative (a noun in the 'to/for/by-X' grammatical form) 'by nature' (phusei) (by nature) modifies the predicate children of wrath, and the imperfect (ongoing or repeated past action) 'we were' (emetha) (we were) names a prior shared state, with 'as also the rest' (hos kai hoi loipoi) (as also the rest) universalizing it. The force toward a native, pre-volitional standing is real. But 'nature' (phusis) across its 14 NT uses carries several senses: birth-origin or natural endowment (Galatians 2:15 Jews by 'nature' (phusei), Romans 2:27 uncircumcision by 'nature' (phusei), Romans 11:21 and 24 natural branches), kind or species (James 3:7), the regular order of things (1 Corinthians 11:14 'nature' (phusis) teaches, Romans 1:26 natural use), and essential constitution (2 Peter 1:4 divine 'nature' (phusis)). Because 'by nature' (phusei) in Ephesians 2:3 can mean by birth-origin or in our essential condition as we then were, it strongly supports a native wrath-status but does not by the word alone fix it as a corruption descending specifically from Adam.

Eph.2.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3498 νεκρός, G3900 παράπτωμα, G0266 ἁμαρτία

Force. 'Being dead in trespasses and in sins' (ontas nekrous tois paraptomasin kai tais hamartiais). The participle 'being' (ontas) (being) names a state of spiritual death in trespasses and sins prior to grace. The condition is described as already the readers' standing, the backdrop against which 2:4-5 sets God's action of making alive. It describes the depth of the fallen state but says nothing directly about its descent from Adam.

Ps.58.3 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H2114 זור

Force. The wicked are estranged from the womb ('from the womb', me-rechem), they go astray from birth ('from the belly', mi-beten) speaking lies. The from-womb and from-birth idioms reinforce the spread-across-the-whole-Old-Testament pattern of sin predating personal moral capacity. It is poetic and describes a class (the wicked) rather than asserting a universal anthropology, so it corroborates rather than carries the verdict.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.5.12	Rom.5.19	openbible	1
Rom.5.12	Rom.5.14	openbible	1
Rom.5.12	1Cor.15.21	openbible	1
Rom.5.12	Rom.6.23	tsk	1
Rom.5.12	Ps.51.5	openbible	1
Ps.51.5	Job.14.4	openbible	1
Ps.51.5	Ps.58.3	tsk	1
Ps.51.5	Eph.2.3	openbible	1
Ps.51.5	Gen.8.21	openbible	1
Ps.51.5	Gen.5.3	openbible	1
Job.14.4	Job.15.14	tsk	1
Job.14.4	Job.25.4	openbible	1
Eph.2.2	Eph.2.3	tsk	1
Eph.2.3	Gen.5.3	tsk	1
Rom.5.16	Gen.3.6	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Rom.5.12 · addressed

The closing clause 'in/because of which all sinned' (eph ho pantes hemarton) is the genuine lexical crux. The relative phrase 'in/because of which' (eph ho) is read causally (because all sinned), consecutively (so that all sinned), or with 'which' (ho) referring to the one man (in whom all sinned), and the aorist (a completed past action) 'all sinned' (hemarton) is a completed past. The causal reading favours a personal-sin ground, the in-whom reading favours inherited guilt. The from-birth verdict survives either reading because Romans 5:14 (death over those who did not sin Adam's way) and 5:19 ('they were constituted' (kathistemi, were constituted) sinners) carry an inherited liability independently of this clause, but the precise mechanism the proposition encodes is left open by the Greek.

Ezek.18.20 · addressed

The son shall not bear the iniquity ('in iniquity', ba-awon) of the father, nor the father the iniquity of the son. This governs judicial liability for personal acts within the covenant community, the level of who is punished in human and covenantal adjudication, not a universal anthropology of origin. It uses the same root 'iniquity' (awon) as Psalm 51:5 but in a courtroom sense. It limits how inherited corruption may be framed (it cannot mean a son is punished for the father's specific deeds in covenant law) without overturning the from-birth pattern of Romans 5 and the Psalms.

Deut.24.16 · addressed

Fathers shall not be put to death for children, nor children for fathers, every man for his own sin. Same judicial-practice horizon as Ezekiel 18:20. It constrains human courts. It does not address the federal or natural solidarity claim in the Pauline 'to all men' (eis pantas anthropous) arc, which operates at the level of universal standing before God rather than penal procedure.

Rom.2.14 · addressed

Gentiles do by nature ('by nature', phusei) the things of the law. This shows the same word 'by nature' (phusei) used in Ephesians 2:3 can denote ordinary natural endowment or instinct rather than a corrupt condition, which is exactly why 'by nature' (phusei) in Ephesians 2:3 cannot by itself fix the by-nature wrath-status as a corruption descending from Adam as opposed to a description of the universal fallen condition. It is addressed by noting that context, not the word 'nature' (phusis) alone, carries the sense in each place.

Concordance traversed

G0076, G0266, G3900, G2288, G2631, G2525, G5449, G3709, G1520, G0444, G4561, G3498, G0268, G3876, G5218, H2342, H5771, H2399, H2931, H2889, H3336

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Eph2.1-hymon-vs-hemon-pronoun at Eph.2.1: impact none. Witnesses vary between 'your' (hymon) and 'our' (hemon) and presence of the pronoun. The lexical pattern that the readers were 'dead' (nekrous) in trespasses survives every reading, so the corruption claim is untouched.

Rom5.12-eph-ho-construal at Rom.5.12: impact minor. This is a construal and translation divergence, not a manuscript split. All extant Greek witnesses read 'in/because of which' (eph ho). The ambiguity is grammatical and lexical, not text-critical. The from-birth verdict rests on Romans 5:14, 5:18, and 5:19 independently, so verdict impact is minor and the mechanism, not the verdict, is what the ambiguity unsettles.

All anchor verses are in Psalms, Job, Genesis, Romans, and Ephesians, outside the ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window (3 John 1:1 to 1:15). No CBGM apparatus (the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a digital tool for tracing manuscript relationships) was examined and none is in scope for this verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. imputed_guilt, transmitted_corruption, inherited_inclination, corporate_solidarity, personal_sin_only

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

transmitted_corruption: supports · Reads Psalm 51:5 ('I was brought forth' (cholalti), brought forth in iniquity), Job 14:4 (no clean from unclean), and Genesis 8:21 ('inclination' (yetser) evil from youth) as locating a real corrupt condition in the line of generation, and Ephesians 2:3 'by nature' (phusei) as the native sharing of that condition. On this lens the proposition's word corruption is exactly right and the from-birth language is its strongest ground.

imputed_guilt: supports · Reads 'of one man' (henos anthropou) and 'in/because of which' (eph ho) (taken as in whom) in Romans 5:12 to 19 as a legal-representative arrangement whose 'trespass' (paraptoma) is reckoned to descendants, with 'condemnation' (katakrima) (forensic condemnation) and 'they were constituted' (katestathesan) (aorist passive (a completed past action, with the subject receiving the action), were constituted) carrying judicial appointment rather than infused corruption. On this lens the inherited element is primarily guilt, and Romans 5:14 (death over non-Adamic-style sinners) is the key support.

inherited_inclination: supports · Reads the OT material, especially Genesis 6:5 and 8:21 'inclination' (yetser) and Psalm 58:3 from the womb, as teaching an inherited evil disposition or bent rather than either imputed legal guilt or total inability. This lens affirms a from-birth sinful inclination, which the proposition's phrase sinful nature can name, while remaining cautious about the stronger legal claim.

corporate_solidarity: supports · Treats Adam as humanity's archetypal head whose act shapes the corporate human situation, so that 'to all men' (eis pantas anthropous) expresses solidarity in a fallen order. Less precise on whether the link is legal or natural, but coheres with the universalizing 'all' (pas) language and with 'so, thus' (houtos) (so) linking the one and the all.

personal_sin_only: complicates · Reads 'in/because of which all sinned' (eph ho pantes hemarton) causally (because all sinned) and treats the universality as the sum of individual sins after Adam's example, denying any inherited corruption or guilt. This lens has a real grammatical foothold in the causal construal of 'in/because of which' (eph ho) and in the aorist (a completed past action) 'all sinned' (hemarton) as completed personal acts. Its weakness is Romans 5:14, where death reigns over 'those not having sinned' (tous me hamartesantas), those who did not sin in Adam's manner, and the aorist passive (a completed past action, with the subject receiving the action) 'they were constituted' (katestathesan) in 5:19, which names a constituting rather than a behaving. So the words press against a pure imitation reading without absolutely excluding a minimal version of it.

The from-birth, pre-volitional sinful condition is supported across four of five lenses and resists the fifth on the grammar of Romans 5:14 and 5:19. The lenses divide not on whether the condition is innate but on its mechanism, imputed guilt versus transmitted corruption versus inherited inclination. The proposition bundles innate sinfulness with a specific descent-from-Adam corruption, and the vocabulary supports the first firmly while underdetermining the second.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Human beings come into existence already in a sinful condition that precedes their own moral acts, and this condition is connected to Adam and places them under divine wrath.

The stem phrases inherited from Adam, sharing in his corruption import a specific transmission mechanism (a corruption descending by inheritance) into the proposition. The from-birth sinful condition and the by-nature wrath-status are lexically supported (Psalm 51:7, Job 14:4, Genesis 8:21, Psalm 58:3, Ephesians 2:3 'by nature' (phusei), Romans 5:14, 5:18, 5:19), so affirms is kept true as in the prior file. Confidence is lowered from high to medium relative to the prior file because the queried lexis shows the mechanism the stem encodes is underdetermined: 'in/because of which' (eph ho) in Romans 5:12 admits causal, consecutive, and in-whom construals that the Greek does not rank, and 'nature' (phusis) in Ephesians 2:3 carries multiple attested senses (birth-origin, kind, natural order, essential constitution), so the words do not by themselves fix inherited corruption as against imputed guilt or merely an inherited inclination. This is a confidence change driven by lexical findings, not an affirms change, so the verdict token (VERDICT-CHANGED:) is not flipped. The neutralized form states the supported core without preloading the contested mechanism.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.51.5
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Job.14.4
morphology	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.8.21
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.5.19
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eph.2.3

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2525
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5449
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2631
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2342
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ps.51.5
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.5.12
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cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.5.12

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